

Video game maker Electronic Arts is with Blu-ray, as are the entertainment companies Twentieth Century Fox, Vivendi Universal, Walt Disney, and, of course, Sony Pictures.

HD-DVD is being promoted by, amongst others, NEC, Sanyo, and the Wintel duo—Microsoft and Intel. Toshiba leads the HD-DVD consortium. Entertainment companies backing HD-DVD are HBO, New Line Cinema, Universal Studios Home Entertainment and Warner Home Video.

What Do HD-DVD Proponents Say?

Blu-ray boasts of higher capacities, and that's enough to make one wonder, "Why HD-DVD?" It appears that Blu-ray has everything going for it, including a lot of support from hardware makers.

But HD-DVD has one key advantage for now: cost. In the case of Blu-ray, new facilities will be required in all areas—disc and player manufacture, and also movie-disc replication. Since the physical specifications of HD-DVD have a lot in common with DVD, most manufacturing plants currently making DVD players, discs and movies can also be used for HD-DVD.

Proponents of the two camps say different things, and sometimes quote obscure sources. We can't be sure who's accurate, but we know that Microsoft and Intel have joined the HD-DVD bandwagon, thus lending some weight to the HD-DVD camp. Here are some things that HD-DVDers (if we can call them that) are likely to say:

- ❑ "HD DVD has a proven 30 GB capacity, while currently, Blu-ray has only delivered 25 GB outside of the lab—this is half of what its proponents promised."
- ❑ "Both formats said they would develop a standard that supports playing of both, DVDs as well as their next-generation standards, but so far, only HD-DVD has delivered."
- ❑ "The capacity for volume production of HD DVD discs is already in place."

And as to Microsoft and Intel backing HD-DVD, they cited the following requirements of "any successful next-generation optical format for high definition," which HD-DVD can deliver right now.

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- ❑ Managed Copy is a guaranteed feature in HD-DVD that enables consumers to make legitimate copies of their discs to a hard disc.
- ❑ Proven low-cost, high-volume manufacturing.
- ❑ HD DVD-ROM discs will offer dual-layer 30 GB discs at launch, compared with BD-ROM discs, which will be limited to (single-layer) 25 GB.
- ❑ The compatibility of HD-DVD with DVD facilitates development of slim drives for integration in notebooks.
- ❑ HD-DVD supports the iHD interactivity standard, that uses XML—and Vista uses XML. Blu-ray does not!

So Which Format Will "Win"?

We're as unsure as anyone else out there! Here's a disjointed set of facts that could possibly have a bearing on the issue.

First, a word about hybrid discs. We mentioned that both camps will initially offer hybrid discs that can be played on existing DVD players. That was a simplification: the truth is that Microsoft and others claim hybrid discs will be a reality with HD-DVD, but probably not so for Blu-ray.

In late September, Richard E Doherty, program manager in Microsoft's media entertainment technology convergence group, stressed the matter of timing in delivering a solution. Saying that "HD-DVD has shown that hybrid discs will be a reality for consumers at launch," he indicated there was "no roadmap for the development and availability of a BD hybrid disc"!

Some say Microsoft will eventually support Blu-ray due to its inherent capacity advantage—there might not be native support for Blu-ray in Vista, initially, but it will be there! Vista is, of course, something one must think about when talking about technological storage and entertainment issues these days.

Who will get to the market first with higher capacities? It's not obvious that it will be Blu-ray. Remember, we spoke about Blu-ray being limited to 25 GB (single-layer) at launch, compared to HD-DVD that would be 30 GB (dual-layer) at launch.

Here's an example of the kind of bickering that seems to be going on these days: two months ago,


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